

Director Competency Assessment and Behavioral Interviewing Framework: An Educational Guide

This comprehensive guide breaks down the core frameworks used to evaluate, onboard, and manage partners and directors. By integrating pathway guidelines, psychological profiling, and rigorous accountability metrics, these tools ensure that professional service firms maintain high standards of governance, performance, and culture.

1. Directorship Pathway Guidelines (Templates 1 & 2)

Benefits: The Directorship Pathway templates provide a transparent, objective, and structured 5-year roadmap for an individual to transition into a partnership role. It removes ambiguity from the promotion process by establishing strict benchmarks for experience, character, and core competencies.

How it helps the Business Owner: Business owners benefit from predictable succession planning and risk mitigation. The framework ensures that incoming partners are culturally aligned, have a proven track record (such as managing \$250k in fees and generating \$125k in organic growth), and are financially responsible. It protects the firm by requiring new partners to have a family trust, be insurable, and maintain pristine personal financial affairs.

How it helps the Advisor: For advisors or assessing partners, these templates serve as a comprehensive evaluation rubric. The Competency Assessment Framework allows advisors to rank candidates on a 1 to 5 scale (from "Needs serious attention" to "Competent to coach others effectively") across critical areas like financial management, workflow scheduling, and delegating.

Who it is suitable for: These templates are ideal for professional service firms, accounting practices, and mid-sized businesses looking to cultivate internal talent for equity partnerships or directorship roles.

2. Enneagram-Based Employment Questions Framework

Benefits: This framework goes beyond standard technical interviews by identifying the deep-seated psychological motivations, stress triggers, and social preferences of candidates based on the 9 Enneagram types. It categorizes individuals into broader work styles, such as Soloists, Initiators, and Cooperators.

How it helps the Business Owner: Owners can use this to strategically build balanced teams and prevent cultural friction. By understanding whether a candidate is an "Achiever" driven by recognition or a "Peacemaker" avoiding conflict, the owner can align roles with natural strengths and anticipate how individuals will react under pressure.

How it helps the Advisor: It provides advisors and HR professionals with highly targeted behavioral interview questions. Instead of generic queries, an advisor can ask an "Investigator (Type 5)" how they cope when they know others are wrong, or ask a "Challenger (Type 8)" how they control

sarcasm when faced with incompetence. This uncovers the candidate's self-awareness and emotional intelligence.

Who it is suitable for: Hiring managers, executive coaches, and advisors conducting advanced vetting for leadership, management, or highly collaborative team roles.

3. Partner Accountability & Conduct Framework

Benefits: This template establishes a robust governance structure through a highly detailed "Conduct & Effect" matrix and a Code of Conduct. It specifically identifies "Boardroom Manipulation Tactics" (like the "Taxi Driver mentality" or "The Assassin") and links behavioral or performance failures directly to financial consequences.

How it helps the Business Owner: It protects the firm's profitability and integrity. The Demerit Points Table objectively ties infractions to profit share entitlement (e.g., accumulating 20 points results in immediate resignation and forfeiture of the client base). Conversely, it incentivizes growth through a Bonus Points System (e.g., an extra *12k bonus for generating* >100k in new client fees).

How it helps the Advisor: It equips advisors and managing partners with a mechanism to manage underperformance or toxic behavior without relying purely on subjective feelings. Tools like the "Yellow Card System" provide structured warnings with expected response times ranging from 24 hours to 90 days. Furthermore, it allows advisors to evaluate partners based on their operational focus as "Finders, Minders, or Grinders".

Who it is suitable for: Existing boards of directors, established partnerships, or executive teams that require strict governance, conflict resolution tools, or formal performance management.

Step-by-Step Implementation Method

Step 1: Define the Pathway Criteria When identifying a 'Partner in Pathway' (P.I.P), allocate an Assessment Partner to them. Introduce the candidate to the **Directorship Pathway 1** guidelines so they understand the 5-year timeline, expected CPD hours, and the requirement to submit at least two formal white papers.

Step 2: Conduct Behavioral and Psychological Vetting During the associate phase, utilize the **Enneagram-Based Employment Questions**. Identify the candidate's core type. Use the targeted questions to evaluate how they handle conflict, prioritize tasks under pressure, and engage in teamwork. Ensure they have the self-awareness required for leadership.

Step 3: Execute the Competency Assessment Use the grid in **Directorship Pathway 2** to conduct a 360-degree review. Have the candidate rate themselves from 1 to 5 on competencies like "Secure Profitable Engagements" and "Chair a formal directors meeting", and compare this against the average ratings from existing partners.

Step 4: Establish Rules of Engagement and Accountability Once accepted as a partner, immediately integrate them into the **Partner Accountability** framework. Have them sign the Code of Conduct. Ensure they understand the definitions of Gross Negligence versus Mistake, and how the Demerit and Bonus Points systems impact their profit share.

Step 5: Ongoing Monitoring and Course Correction Regularly assess partner performance using the Finder/Minder/Grinder matrix. If a partner displays disruptive behavior (e.g., "The Bully & The Donkey" boardroom tactics), issue a **Yellow Card** to put them 'on notice' with a specific timeline (e.g., 24 hours or 7 days) to correct the behavior before demerits are applied.

Common Q&A

1. How long does the pathway to becoming a partner typically take?

The maximum 'Pathway Period' is five years. After this, the individual is either assessed as successful and commences sharing equity/risk, or they are 'exited' as terminally unsuitable.

2. How is a candidate's readiness objectively scored?

The Competency Assessment Framework uses a 1 to 5 rating scale ranging from "Needs serious attention" (1) to "Competent to coach others effectively" (5). This is applied across operational, financial, and managerial competencies.

3. What happens if a partner intentionally sabotages an initiative or acts unethically?

The Partner Accountability framework handles this via the Demerit Points Table and the Conduct Matrix. For instance, "Machiavellian" or "Gross Negligence" behaviors carry heavy demerit points. Accumulating 20 points in 12 months results in immediate resignation and trade restrictions.

4. How does the Enneagram framework improve the interview process?

Instead of asking generic questions, the Enneagram framework targets the specific weaknesses and stress responses of 9 distinct personality types. For example, asking a Type 7 (Enthusiast) how they organize themselves when faced with multiple tasks addresses their natural tendency to become scattered.

5. What is the "Yellow Card" system?

It is an interim warning system used to notify a director that their behavior is unacceptable and they are 'on notice.' It requires a serious attempt to improve within agreed response time guidelines (ranging from Immediate/24 hours to Normal/90 days).

6. How are partners evaluated on their business development versus technical work?

The framework categorizes working IN and ON the business through three profiles: Finder (securing new clients), Minder (maintaining existing relations), and Grinder (completing technical service delivery). Performance is ranked based on achieving specific targets within these roles.

Source Summary Table

Template Name	Core Focus & Contents
Directorship Pathway 1	Details General Pathway Criteria (5-year maximum), Experience Consideration Guidelines (e.g., 30 months firm experience, \$125k fee growth), and Character Guidelines (e.g., insurable, family trust) for incoming partners.
Directorship Pathway 2	Focuses on the Director Competency Assessment across "Get Organised, Get the job, Do the job." Outlines core competencies like delegation, debt recovery (H.E.A.T process), and financial management alongside a 1-5 rating matrix.
Enneagram Based Employment Questions	Explains the 9 Enneagram personality types in a business context (e.g., Reformer, Achiever, Peacemaker) and provides targeted behavioral interview questions to uncover underlying motivations and stress responses.
Partner Accountability	Defines Boardroom Manipulation Tactics, a Demerit/Bonus points system tied to profit share, Conduct & Effect matrices for Ethics, Skills, and Motivation, and outlines the Yellow Card warning system.

If-Then Logic Branch Table for AI Implementation

Logic Branch	IF (Condition / Trigger)	THEN (Action / Next Step)	Additional Context / Notes
Pathway Initiation	IF the firm states, "We want to promote a senior staff member to partner"...	THEN initiate the "Directorship Pathway 1" checklist. Verify if the candidate has 30 months of firm experience and has managed \$250k in fees.	Establishes the baseline requirements before spending time on complex competency testing.
Competency Assessment	IF the candidate meets baseline pathway requirements...	THEN deploy the "Directorship Pathway 2" Competency Rating Matrix. Ask the candidate and their peers to rate them from 1-5 on core competencies.	Focuses on identifying skill gaps (e.g., Financial Management or Presenting) that require coaching.
Behavioral Profiling	IF interviewing a candidate and they present as an "Achiever (Type 3)"...	THEN ask: "How do you cope when those around you appear to be having more success than you are?"	Uses the "Enneagram based employment questions" to test emotional intelligence and competitive drivers.

Boardroom Conflict	IF a partner is continuously shutting down creative discussions with cold logic...	THEN reference the "Boardroom Manipulation Tactics" to identify if they are acting as "The Assassin" or using "Scorched Earth" tactics.	Helps accurately label toxic behavior for objective review rather than emotional arguing.
Conduct Warning	IF a partner consistently displays tardiness or 'grumpiness' without improvement...	THEN issue a "Yellow Card" citing the Agreed Response Time Guidelines (e.g., Priority 2 / 30 Days to correct).	Serves as an interim measure. If they fail to correct, this escalates to formal Demerit Points.
Performance Tracking	IF a partner exceeds their targets by generating over \$100k in new combined client fees...	THEN refer to the "Bonus Points System" and award the set bonus (e.g., \$12k) prior to profit share calculations.	Reinforces positive "Finder" behavior and growth through transparent financial incentives.
Severe Infraction	IF a partner commits Gross Negligence resulting in catastrophic market fallout...	THEN apply the "Ethics Conduct & Effect" matrix to calculate the Demerit Points (e.g., Base 4pts + Effect 8pts = 12 Demerit Points).	If points hit 20 within 12 months, it triggers immediate resignation and trade restrictions.